

The transcendence of the one national deity—Ahura Mazda, “the God of the Aryans,” Yahweh, “the God of Israel”—became more and more marked with time; and ultimately the nation reached a real monotheism by this road. In each case there is a possibility that the Founder reached it ages before. It may be added that the lines of religious declension were much the same. The old polytheism in each case constantly threatened to return. Mithra and Anahita might in theory be only *yazata*, angels subordinated to the only God, just as in medieval Christianity Michael and the Virgin were by theologians kept wholly apart from Deity. But with the populace the distinction was unreal, and polytheism virtually returned, as it did throughout the history of Israel before the Captivity.

The part played by the Prophet may be compared with suggestive results. Zarathushtra stands solitary in the history of Parsism, while Moses has a series of successors, some of whom were at least as great as himself. There lies the most important part of the ultimate difference between the destiny of the religions. In other respects the parallel will hold. Each Founder was credited in later days with a complete legislative system, which in Zarathushtra's case was the work of men wholly alien¹ from his spirit. By way of compensation, the men who mis-

¹ Here I must chronicle the fact that my friend Prof. Jackson sprinkles queries about these two words. His opinion is worth so much more than mine that the reader should be told when I am venturing without his company. My main contention is that the *ritual* of the Vendidad was alien to Zarathushtra, who, as I understand him, had nothing of the ritual or the sacerdotal in his system. But I have no doubt that without their adaptation Zarathushtra's thought would have failed to survive.